

CRIME Branch



SAURABH SINGH

They go around shouting slogans and hurling abuses at each other but if there is one thing that political parties of all hues have in common, it is their love for candidates with criminal backgrounds. And it would seem that the big two—the Congress and BJP—are trying to outdo each other. In the 14th Lok Sabha, the BJP had 23 such MPs while the Congress lagged, but not too far behind, with 17 MPs. Of the 543 MPs in the 14th Lok Sabha, 125 had criminal cases pending against them. They belonged to different parties, ensuring that there was equitable distribution of the tainted. "Civil society organisations are demanding that politics be freed from crime," says Jagdeep Choikkar, former dean of IIM-Ahmedabad and founder member, Association for Democratic Reforms, which compiled the list.

by Shafi Rahman

The Lone RANGER

Ram Vilas Paswan may be a kingmaker in Bihar and even nurture visions of being prime minister, but in Jharkand, part of Bihar until recently, he has no suitors. The three major UPA partners—the Congress, Lalu's RJD and Shibu Soren's JMM—are in no mood to accommodate Paswan in the rainbow alliance. Though he stood by Soren when the former Jharkand chief minister was under a cloud, Soren is keeping professional relations above personal equations after the announcement of elections. Undeterred, Paswan's LJP is contesting six seats from where it has never won. by Amitabh Srivastava



Electoral High

Across the country, *bijli*, *sadak* and *paani* are the major issues but in Uttar Pradesh's Barabanki constituency, cultivation of opium is the main plank for Congress candidate P.L. Punia. He says if elected, he will have the ban on its cultivation lifted. by Subhash Mishra

1 polling booth will be set up in the Gir Forest in Gujarat, home to the Asiatic Lion, to enable the lone voter, a priest, to cast his vote.

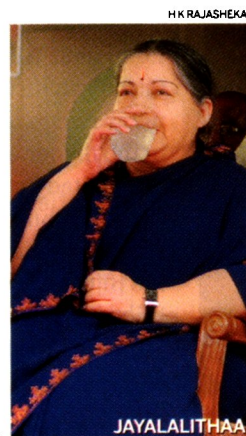
RELATIVE MERITS

The Gowda clan now has company. Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa's son Raghavendra is contesting on a BJP ticket from Shimoga and state Congress chief R.V. Deshpande's son is tipped for the ticket from Karwar.

In the Fast Lane

One of the ironies of politics is the gluttony for votes leading to hunger strikes. Last week, AIADMK chief Jayalalithaa cast aside her indifference to the plight of Sri Lankan Tamils and sat on a fast in Chennai. She's not alone. Politicians of all hues in Tamil Nadu are changing stripes hoping for an electoral bounty.

by S. Senthil Kumar



H K RAJASHEKAR

Nine LIVES

If elected, JD(U)'s George Fernandes and Congress's Giridhar Gamang, who are both serving their ninth term, will be the senior-most members of the 15th Lok Sabha.